he set up a makeshift office in a Kochi hotel room to create photographic evidence suggesting he had conducted an official verification visit to an IRCON office. In statements to central agencies, he allegedly claimed he acted on the instructions of Agarwal and senior engineers. These have now become the basis for their arrests, though Agarwal's lawyers argue that the testimony of an accused presented as a key conspirator cannot be relied on without corroboration.

NOTHING TENDER HERE

The question being asked: if IRCON had already warned PHED about forged documents, why did the financial committee approve work orders for the accused firms on May 9, 2023, and payments of nearly Rs 112 crore released? Agarwal maintains the tenders were cancelled once the fraud was confirmed, that payments were made only for work completed, and that any wrongful payments can be recovered. "There was no loss to the government in tenders; bad execution is a different issue beyond my purview," he told INDIA TODAY after prosecution sanction against him was given. Challenging the FIR against him before the Rajasthan High Court, he argued that nearly 90 per cent of the tenders under scrutiny were approved during the tenure of his predecessor, Sudhansh Pant, who was ACS, PHED, from January 2021 to April 2022. Sources who worked with Pant then say he found no cause to intervene as the first complaints came 10 months after he demitted office. Pant has since had multiple postings at the Centre and state, including a return as chief secretary in 2024 before going back to the Centre in 2025. He declined to comment on the issue.

Lawyer T.N. Sharma, who has filed many PILs related to the scam, says the investigation is moving too slowly. "Multiple agencies have been investigating these cases since 2023, yet progress remains limited. They have focused largely on two firms, but a dozen more deserve scrutiny. There is also a senior engineer who certified fake bank guarantees and executed thousands of works," he says. Also among them is a Jaipur-based private university that allegedly submitted fake experience details and inflated village coverage figures to secure awareness campaign contracts worth crores.

Quality audits at JJM projects further reveal the depth of the mess. In several locations, pipelines were laid without ascertaining whether water was available. Substandard water tanks, 'duplicate' job works, recovery of pipes suspected to have been stolen from JJM projects in Haryana are only some of the wrongdoings in a mile-long list.


TAPPED OUT Ex-PHED minister Mahesh Joshi in court, May 7

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In fact, the scandal in Rajasthan so worried New Delhi that it triggered policy changes at the national level. The Centre has now expanded the list of inadmissible expenses under JJM from seven categories to 10. The revised framework also focuses on ensuring water supply rather than merely creating infrastructure. Across India, many villages have tap connections but receive little or no water because the emphasis was on asset-creation rather than on service delivery. Politics has inevitably sharpened the controversy. Union tourism minister Gajendra Singh Shekhawat, who was Jal Shakti minister during JJM's rollout, points to the arrests as evidence of action being taken. Gehlot, however, views the arrests as a case of 'vindictiveness' on the part of the BJP government. "In fact, Agarwal's arrest has so frightened the bureaucracy that it has caused policy paralysis," he alleges. CM Sharma rejects that charge. "Our government has acted against corruption at every level...and JJM is no exception," he told INDIA TODAY.



"The situation is delicate. If we have to investigate the JJM scam fully, my department would be emptied out"

KANHAIYA LAL CHAUDHARY
PHED minister, Rajasthan

In all this, the greater challenge of reaching water to the parched regions of the state remains unmet. For instance, in Rohidala village in Barmer, near the Indo-Pak border, women still walk several kilometres to fetch water. Nearly 700 km away, in Kheri village near the capital Jaipur, blue JJM pipelines lie brittle and dry. And therein lies the irony of the Jal Jeevan Mission in Rajasthan: thousands of crores spent, thousands of kilometres of pipelines laid, and yet, for thousands of households, tap water remains a pipe dream. ■